



ORPHANET

 Belgium

2025

TEAM

Country coordinator/IS: Annabelle Calomme

National governance and coordination of the project;
Management of Belgian database content (collection, analysis, registration, updates);
Management of the national website (FR);
Coordination of the OD4RD national hub.



Terminology translator: Kim Van Roey

Dutch translation of the Orphanet nomenclature, classification and RD encyclopedia;
Dutch translation of HPO terms;
Dutch translation of the Orphanet portal;
Management of the national website (NL).



Institutional framework

Hosted by Sciensano, the Scientific Institute of Public Health; endorsed by the Ministry of Health.



PARTNERS

National Accompanying Committee:

FPS Public Health, NIHDI (sponsor), Sciensano.

Internal partnerships (Sciensano):

- Belgian Genetic Test Database (BGTD)
- Central Registry for Rare Diseases (CRRD)
- RD specific registries (CF, NMD, Hirschsprung)
- National Reference Centres for rare infectious diseases

External partnerships:

- RaDiOrg, Belgian umbrella organisation for RD patients
- Belgian College for Human Genetics and Rare Diseases

Orphanet Belgium website:

- French version: <https://orphanet.site/belgique>
- Dutch version: <https://orphanet.site/belgie>

NATIONAL CONTEXT

- **At least 500,000 people** in Belgium are living with a rare disease.
- Belgium is a member of the **Orphanet network since 2001**.
- Belgium participates in **all 24 ERNs**.

HIGHLIGHTS

1. National RD Plan: contribution to the drafting of the 2nd plan (2026-2030).

2. RD coding: participation in OD4RD2 (WP4)

- Organisation of trainings on Orphanet nomenclature and RD coding in hospitals, ERN-centres and with GPs;
- Contribution to the GitHub;
- Advocacy to promote the adoption and consistent use of ORPHAcodes.

3. Translation activity (Dutch): 6,861 items translated (2,284 abstracts / 4,577 definitions); 29,980 terms translated (preferred /synonyms/ keywords): 26,822 active clinical entities / 106 functional entities / 4 pharmacological entities / 3,048 inactive entities.

4. Transnational activities: participation in JARDIN JA (WP8) , ERDERA and Interreg VISIMalRares.

5. Awareness and networking: RD Day events, collaboration with the Patient Expert Center , report for the EU Parliament, member of the NEED project advisory board (applicability to RDs), etc.



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CHALLENGES

1. **Sustainability**: finalization of the new Sciensano-NIHDI contract to secure structural funding for 2026; ongoing integration of Sciensano into the Orphanet AISBL.
2. **National context**: Belgium's multilingual environment (3 languages: Dutch, French, German) and complex institutional landscape ("institutional lasagna") significantly increase workload and complicate the nationwide implementation of projects.
3. **Designation of RD centres**: no legal basis for formal recognition of expertise.
4. **ORPHAcoding**: limited support from national health authorities (no legal framework or financial incentives); transition to SNOMED CT® as the common national reference terminology in Belgian electronic health records; resistance among some clinicians to adopt ORPHAcodes.
5. **Database completeness**: low response rates from professionals and institutions hinder the completeness and annual update of expert resources on the Orphanet portal.

PLAN FOR 2026 — NEXT STEPS

1. **Strengthen Orphanet content**: expand and update Belgian data; improve quality and completeness.; continue Dutch translation work.
2. **Increase visibility**: promote Orphanet to healthcare professionals, researchers, and patient groups; enrich the Orphanet Belgium website with more input from patient associations.
3. **Support the national RD strategy**: enhance collaboration with federal authorities for the implementation of the new Rare Disease Plan.
4. **Advance ORPHAcoding**: continue OD4RD2 and launch OD4RD3; improve interoperability with RD registries; work with the FPS Terminology Centre to support ORPHAcodes alongside SNOMED CT®.
5. **Launch of Interreg VISIMalRares (BE-FR)**: provide RD training in cross-border hospitals; develop a Belgian version of the RDK tool (incl. Dutch translation of HPO terms).